A Collection on Suicide

By Patrick Roche and Jared Singer

Contains the following color-coded, interspersed poems:

- *Every 40 Seconds by Patrick Roche*
- *I Have Never Been Suicidal by Jared Singer*
- *A Letter to Sarah . . . by Jared Singer*

NOTE: Each poem should have a different voice for the most impactful presentation

Every 40 seconds.

This is not a list poem.

This is a eulogy for those swallowed by their own minds.

This is a call to arms, a call to speak.

This is not family gatherings when I mention mental health and am told not to spoil the turkey,

That it is uncouth, impolite,

That it is better to stay silent.

This is taking that silence and breaking it with my hands, with my teeth and tongue.

This is people with mental illness banging our heads against the walls, not out of insanity but to try to make some noise, to be heard.

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Too often we are ashamed, too often we are in the shadows.

In 2014, the World Health Organization released a report stating that at least 800,000 people commit suicide every year. That averages to 1 person every 40 seconds.

INTRODUCTION

Every 40 seconds . . . by the end of this presentation 10 people will have taken their lives.

A Collection on Suicide containing Every 40 Seconds by Patrick Roche, I Have Never Been Suicidal and A Letter to Sarah Contemplating Super Powers by Jared Singer

I have never been suicidal,
never wanted to kill myself

I have always believed that life is a gift.
Sometimes it's a gift you don't want,

an itchy sweater you wish you could return.
I have never wanted to kill myself,

but I have wanted to die
Prayed for it.

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Every 40 seconds.

Suicide is not always a banshee wailing against your eardrums, it is a child playing hide-and-seek behind your friends smile.

They will not wear it openly, they cannot hold it's hand and introduce it to you, it is always invisible.

Suicide is a lonely ghost desperate to give itself playmates.

If you'd only told us something was wrong

we could've held you

told you we loved you.

We could have helped.

[Suicide] is not a permanent solution to a temporary problem, these are so rarely temporary problems.

It is aiming for a long nights sleep after years of insomnia.

It is the seduction of safety and simplicity.

Sometimes it is careful planning;

Drafting the note . . . . Every 40 seconds.

If I could travel through time,

I would go back to the moment

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before it was too late.

Right before the moment you wrote a suicide note that started Dear Jared:

Inspecting your apartment for beams that can support your weight.

Or it is a flip switch given the right trigger, or no trigger at all.

It is painting a target on the highway divider.

It is imaging the phone call my mother will get in the middle of a nap.

Sometimes it is sudden, it is not always arriving-

At the most convenient time but the clock keeps ticking.

Every 40 seconds.

I'd always thought that despair

would feel empty. That's how it's

always described. It isn't --

it is full and terror-cold.

I am happier than I have ever been.

I still have a hard time believing in myself,

use the word broken too much.

I have never been suicidal, but now I love the living.
I stopped looking at life as good or bad, a series
of snapshots where each was either a reason
to live or a reason to die.
I have not always wanted to live. For a long time I
couldn't even imagine what joy would feel like.
It's a melody. It's a tide. It is full and warm.
Every 40 seconds.
This is not a list poem.
This is the tea kettle rising to a soprano screech but you
keep ignoring it to watch TV,
It keeps whistling and crying but you keep ignoring it;
How much noise do I have to make?
When we tell you we are suicidal, it is a cry for help but
that's not a sign of weakness.
This is not a sign of weakness.
This is saying we're fighting and
and we've been fighting with every weapon
and fist we have.
We've crashed against the cliff side, broken and

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splintered, but we're still fighting with whatever we can.
I'm using my voice, it's all I have left.
Every 40 seconds.
If I could regenerate any damage to my body,
I would double back flip belly flop
off the tallest building I could find.
I would make you watch.
Would not tell you it won't kill me.
When my body hits the ground,
turns bone to dust,
when blood splatters across your face
there will be a moment
where your heart stops,
where the belly drops out of your everything.
I would calmly walk over to you and say
yeah, ever since you killed yourself
it's been like that for all of us
All of the time.
Over the years, I've written different versions of my
suicide note.
On the nights I almost took my life, I always deleted or

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threw away the note rather than sending it or leaving it for someone, I assumed the words would just make them uncomfortable.

I'm doing this now because I know you will be the one to find me

because of all of my friends I think you're the one whose strong enough to take it.

What made you think I was strong enough to take this?

If I'm going to die, better to do it without all that fuss; better to do it in silence.

Hundreds of thousands of people are dying in silence and because of silence.

If you'd only told us something was wrong

we could've held you

told you we loved you.

We could have helped.

This is not a list poem, this is saying we can keep each other breathing.

This is speaking louder than the stigma and hoping someone will listen

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Philip Roche
ISBN: NSDA Approved Website
https://themighty.com/2019/06/slam-poetry-mental-illness/
Publisher: The Mighty.com
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****NOTE: Lines from Every 40 Seconds are shown in BLACK***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jared Singer
Book: Forgive Yourself These Tiny Acts of Self-Destruction
ISBN: 978-1943735617
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2019

****NOTE: Lines from I Have Never Been Suicidal are shown in GREEN***

****NOTE: Lines from A Letter to Sarah Contemplating Super Powers are shown in ORANGE***

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